Step 21 - Counter Width and Rollover ..... 1
Reference Note ..... 1
Learning Objectives ..... 1
1. What is Counter Width? ..... 2
2. What Is Rollover? ..... 2
8-bit Counter ..... 2
3. System Counter Wraparound ..... 3
Conceptual Example ..... 3
4. Why ARM Chose 64 Bits ..... 3
5. Rollover Time Example ..... 4
6. Practical Meaning ..... 4
7. Why This Matters ..... 4
8. Timer Programming Example ..... 5
9. Could Rollover Ever Matter? ..... 5
10. Safe Counter Comparisons ..... 6
11. Relationship to Counter Scaling ..... 6
12. Physical and Virtual Counters ..... 7
Architecture Summary ..... 7
Common Misconceptions ..... 8
Misconception 1 ..... 8
Misconception 2 ..... 8
Misconception 3 ..... 8
Misconception 4 ..... 8
Key Takeaways ..... 9
Knowledge Check ..... 9
Q1 ..... 9
Q2 ..... 9
Q3 ..... 9
Q4 ..... 9

Q5 ..... 10
Answer Key ..... 10

# Step 21 - Counter Width and Rollover

## Reference Note

This chapter is based on concepts described in the ARM Generic Timer Architecture documentation.

Previous chapters explained:

- System Counter
- Counter Frequency
- Physical Counter
- Virtual Counter
- Timers
- Virtualization

This chapter explains:

How large is the System Counter?
Can it overflow?
What happens when it wraps around?
Should software worry about rollover?

The short answer is:

ARM uses a 64-bit counter specifically so rollover is practically never a concern.

# Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should understand:

- Why ARM uses a 64-bit counter

- What rollover means
- Counter wraparound behavior
- How long rollover takes
- Why rollover is rarely a practical issue
- Safe time comparison techniques

# 1. What is Counter Width?

Counter width defines:

How many unique count values
the counter can represent.

Example:

| Counter Width | Maximum Value |
|---|---|
| 8-bit | 255 |
| 16-bit | 65,535 |
| 32-bit | 4,294,967,295 |
| 64-bit | 18,446,744,073,709,551,615 |

ARM Generic Timer counters are:

64-bit

# 2. What Is Rollover?

All counters eventually reach their maximum value.

Example:

### 8-bit Counter

| Current Value | Next Value |
|---|---|
| 252 | 253 |

| | |
|---|---|
| 253 | 254 |
| 254 | 255 |
| 255 | 0 |

The counter wraps back to:

0

This behavior is called:

Rollover
Wraparound
Overflow

# 3. System Counter Wraparound

A 64-bit System Counter behaves similarly.

### Conceptual Example

| Current Value | Next Value |
|---|---|
| 2^64 - 3 | 2^64 - 2 |
| 2^64 - 2 | 2^64 - 1 |
| 2^64 - 1 | 0 |

After the maximum value:

Counter wraps to zero.

# 4. Why ARM Chose 64 Bits

ARM timers must support:

- Servers
- Networking Equipment
- Industrial Systems

- Automotive Systems
- Long Uptime Devices

A 32-bit counter would overflow too frequently.

A 64-bit counter provides:

Extremely long rollover times.

# 5. Rollover Time Example

Assume:

Counter Frequency = 24 MHz

Maximum count:

2^64
=
18,446,744,073,709,551,616

Time to rollover:

2^64 / 24,000,000

Result:

| Unit | Approximate Duration |
|---|---|
| Seconds | 768,614,336,404 |
| Years | ~24,000+ years |

# 6. Practical Meaning

Suppose a system boots today.

At 24 MHz:

Counter rollover occurs

thousands of years later.

For essentially all real-world systems:

Rollover never occurs during operation.

# 7. Why This Matters

Software frequently performs:

EndCount - StartCount

to measure elapsed time.

Example:

| Start Count | 1,000,000 |
|---|---|
| End Count | 1,500,000 |

Calculation:

500,000 ticks elapsed

This works because rollover is extremely unlikely during normal measurements.

# 8. Timer Programming Example

Suppose:

| Counter | Value |
|---|---|
| Current Count | 1,000,000 |
| Delay | 24,000 |

Program:

CVAL
=

1,024,000

The huge range of a 64-bit counter makes deadline calculations simple and safe.

# 9. Could Rollover Ever Matter?

Technically:

Yes

Practically:

Almost never.

Potential cases:

| Scenario | Consideration |
|---|---|
| Formal Verification | Must consider rollover |
| Architecture Validation | Must consider rollover |
| Long-Term Mathematical Analysis | Must consider rollover |
| Ordinary Systems | Usually irrelevant |

# 10. Safe Counter Comparisons

Good approach:

Elapsed = EndCount - StartCount

Example:

| Start | End |
|---|---|
| 1,000,000 | 1,024,000 |

Elapsed:

24,000

This is the standard approach used throughout timer software.

# 11. Relationship to Counter Scaling

Counter Scaling changes:

Count Increment Amount

but does not change:

Counter Width

Therefore:

| Feature | Affected by Scaling? |
|---|---|
| Counter Width | No |
| Rollover Point | No |
| Increment Size | Yes |

# 12. Physical and Virtual Counters

Both counters ultimately depend on the same underlying System Counter.

| Counter | Width |
|---|---|
| CNTPCT_EL0 | 64-bit |
| CNTVCT_EL0 | 64-bit |

Therefore:

Same rollover characteristics.

# Architecture Summary

| Component | Property |
| --- | --- |
| System Counter | 64-bit |
| Physical Counter | 64-bit View |
| Virtual Counter | 64-bit View |
| Maximum Count | 2^64 - 1 |
| After Maximum | Wraps to Zero |
| Practical Impact | Minimal |

# Common Misconceptions

## Misconception 1

The System Counter never overflows.

False.

It eventually wraps.

## Misconception 2

Rollover occurs frequently.

False.

A 64-bit counter at typical frequencies lasts thousands of years.

## Misconception 3

Counter Scaling changes rollover behavior.

False.

Scaling changes increment size, not counter width.

### Misconception 4

Virtual Counter has a different width.

False.

Both Physical and Virtual Counters expose 64-bit values.

## Key Takeaways

| Concept | Key Point |
| --- | --- |
| System Counter Width | 64-bit |
| Maximum Value | 2^64 - 1 |
| After Maximum | Wraps to 0 |
| Rollover | Theoretical concern |
| Practical Impact | Negligible |
| Physical Counter | 64-bit |
| Virtual Counter | 64-bit |

## Knowledge Check

### Q1

What is the width of the ARM System Counter?

### Q2

What happens when the counter reaches its maximum value?

### Q3

Why did ARM choose a 64-bit counter?

### Q4

Does Counter Scaling change the rollover point?

### Q5

Do Physical and Virtual Counters have different widths?

# Answer Key

| Question | Answer |
|---|---|
| Q1 | 64 bits |
| Q2 | It wraps to zero |
| Q3 | To support extremely long uptime and accurate timekeeping |
| Q4 | No |
| Q5 | No, both expose 64-bit values |